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LEANING TOWER OF DELHI

MANAGING THE SOVIET INVASION AND WITHDRAWAL

'We [India] have been assured that Soviet troops will be withdrawn when requested to do so by the Afghan government ... we have no reason to doubt the assurances particularly from a friendly country like the Soviet Union with whom we have close ties'.

Brajesh Mishra, India's Permanent Representative at the UN, January 1980[1]

'India's non-alignment should be genuine, [not] tilted like the leaning tower of Pisa'.

Madhu Dandavate, Janata Party leader at a debate in the Lok Sabha, February 1980[2]

'We [Afghans] are unhappy with the Government of India for not supporting the Afghan people and for supporting the Soviet troops. But that has not lessened our admiration and affection for Indians, who were close to us and who had helped us before the Soviet invasion and occupation'.

An Afghan exile from Zahir Shah's group to an R&AW officer in Geneva, 1986.[3]

U-Turn

Ram D. Sathe, a senior diplomat and then India's foreign secretary for just over a month, was asleep when his phone rang at 11.15 PM on 27 December 1979.[4] The joint secretary (JS) at the Eastern Europe desk of the MEA was on the line.[5] Yuli